IDAHO

The Gem State



Idaho has always been a state that feeds people. Its volcanic soil grows potatoes of almost unreasonable quality—starchy, dense, and flavorful in a way that flat-land varieties simply cannot match. Its rivers run cold and clear, and its ranches stretch wide across the Snake River Plain, raising cattle on high-desert grasses beneath a sky that seems larger here than anywhere else. It was only a matter of time before someone figured out that the best things Idaho produced—beef and potatoes—belonged together on the same plate.

The story of finger steaks begins in Boise in the early 1950s, in an establishment of a kind that barely exists anymore: the supper club. The Torch Lounge is widely credited as the birthplace of the dish, where tender strips of beef tenderloin were battered and dropped into hot oil, emerging golden and crackling outside and impossibly juicy within. The timing was no accident. Post-war America was flush with a new prosperity, and working-class families across the West were eating out with a regularity that would have seemed extravagant a decade earlier.

What made the finger steak distinctly Idahoan was the context in which it was eaten. This was not fine dining reaching downward—it was working people's food, served fast and hot, eaten with your hands if the mood struck. Ranchers, potato farmers, mill workers, and railroad men all found something familiar in a strip of battered beef that asked nothing complicated of the person eating it.

The fries alongside were never an afterthought. Idaho's potatoes—an industry that traces to a mission garden near Lapwai in 1836, though the Russet Burbank did not become the state's signature until the 20th century—fried to a texture other states could only approximate: crisp and shatteringly thin outside, pillowy and steaming within.

Together—the crisp battered beef, the golden fries, the tangy, creamy dipping sauce—this is a meal that tastes like the Snake River Plain at dusk, like the end of a long workday, like somewhere specific and proud. Take your time with the oil temperature and trust the potato. What lands in front of you needs no reservation and no ceremony—just an appetite, and the good sense to know that when a place grows the two best things on the plate, it ought to serve them side by side.



FINGER STEAKS WITH FRY SAUCE AND FRENCH FRIES

Born in a 1950s Boise supper club: battered beef strips, Idaho Russet fries, and a fry sauce that settled the debate.

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1½ lb. beef tenderloin or boneless sirloin steak, cut into thick strips
- 1 egg
- 2 cups buttermilk
- 2 Tbsp Montreal steak seasoning
- 3 cups all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp onion salt
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Marinate the beef*: In a large bowl, beat together the egg, buttermilk, Montreal seasoning, and ½ cup of flour until smooth. Add the beef strips and toss to coat well, then cover and refrigerate for at least 2 hours.
2. *Bread the steak strips*: In another large shallow bowl, sift together the remaining 2½ cups of flour, garlic powder, onion salt, salt, and pepper. Remove the steak strips from the buttermilk batter, letting any excess drip off, then dredge each piece in the seasoned flour. Place on a baking sheet and freeze until firm, about 1 hour.
3. *Fry the steak strips*: Heat the oil to 370°F (185°C) in a deep fryer or a large, heavy-bottomed pot. Carefully drop a few frozen steak pieces into the hot oil at a time, being careful not to overcrowd the fryer, and fry until golden brown and crispy, about 5 minutes.
4. *Drain and repeat*: Remove the fried finger steaks with a slotted spoon and drain on a paper towel-lined plate. Repeat with the remaining steak strips, letting the oil return to temperature between batches.

FRY SAUCE

Yield: about 1 cup

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup mayonnaise
- ½ cup ketchup
- 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce (optional)
- ½ tsp paprika
- ¼ tsp garlic powder (optional)
- Salt and pepper, to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Combine*: In a small bowl, combine the mayonnaise and ketchup, then stir in the Worcestershire sauce, paprika, and garlic powder, if using, until smooth and evenly combined. Season with salt and pepper, to taste.
2. *Chill and serve*: Refrigerate for at least 30 minutes to let the flavors meld, then serve chilled as a dipping sauce for the Idaho finger steaks and French fries.

FRENCH FRIES

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large russet potatoes, peeled
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying
- Salt, to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Cut and soak the potatoes*: Cut the peeled potatoes lengthwise into ¼- to ½-inch-thick slices, then cut the slices into fry-shaped sticks. Soak in a large bowl of cold water for at least 30 minutes, or up to a few hours, to draw out excess starch.
2. *Dry the potatoes*: Drain the potatoes well and pat them completely dry with paper towels—this step is crucial for achieving crispy fries.
3. *First fry*: Heat 2–3 inches of oil in a deep fryer or a large, heavy-bottomed pot to 300°F (150°C). Working in batches so you don't overcrowd the fryer, fry the potato sticks for 3–5 minutes, until softened but not yet browned. Remove with a slotted spoon and transfer to a wire rack or paper towel-lined plate to drain and cool.
4. *Second fry*: Increase the oil temperature to 375°F (190°C). Once hot, fry the partially cooked fries again in batches for another 2–4 minutes, until golden and crisp.
5. *Season and serve*: Remove the fries with a slotted spoon onto a paper towel-lined plate. Season immediately with salt to taste, and serve hot.



Beef from the plain, potatoes from the volcanic soil, and supper with no ceremony at all.

